

Absolutely — **cost** is a very strong polysemy target because your passage uses it in two closely related ways:

> “It would **cost** a fortune...”

> “...that would **cost me** around three to five thousand Hong Kong dollars...”

Here **cost** means **require a certain amount of money to obtain, buy, or do something**. But the family also covers **price/expense as a noun, personal sacrifice, consequences, business costing, legal costs, and the fixed expression at all costs**.

Word family: **cost / costly**

Base word: cost

Verb forms: cost, costs, cost, costing

Noun: cost

Related adjective: costly

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / verb (動詞)

Important irregularity:

> present: cost

> past: cost

> past participle: cost

Not usually:

> ***costed*** ❌

except in a separate business sense meaning “calculate the cost of something,” which we’ll cover below.

Meaning in your passage: **cost = require an amount of money — 花費 ; 需付.....**

Your sentence:

> “It would **cost a fortune**...”

and:

> “...that would **cost me** around three to five thousand Hong Kong dollars...”

Here **cost** means:

> **to require a particular amount of money to buy, obtain, produce, or do something.**

****繁體中文：****

****購買、取得或進行某事時需要支付某個金額；花費、要價、需付****

Natural translation:

> “It would cost a fortune.”

「那會****非常昂貴 / 要花一大筆錢****。」

> “It would cost me around three to five thousand Hong Kong dollars.”

「那大概要****花我三千至五千港元****。」

So here:

> ****cost = 需要支付多少金錢****

1. ****cost + amount = 花費；價格為.....****

The core verb meaning.

Practice 1 — Source

> “It would ****cost**** a fortune.”

「那會****花掉一大筆錢****。」

Practice 2

> “The frame ****cost**** five hundred dollars.”

「那個畫框****花了五百元****。」

Practice 3

> “How much does the ticket cost?”

「這張票****多少錢****？」

****cost = 某物 / 某事需要支付特定金額****

2. **cost + person + amount = 花某人.....錢**

Your second source pattern.

Practice 4

> “The reproduction would **cost me** around four thousand dollars.”

「那幅複製畫大概要**花我四千元**。」

Practice 5

> “The repair cost us more than expected.”

「維修費**比預期花了我們更多錢**。」

cost + person + amount = 某件事令某人需要支付某個金額

3. **cost = noun, price/amount of money required — 費用；成本；價錢**

A major noun use.

Practice 6

> “The total **cost** was higher than expected.”

「總**費用**比預期高。」

Practice 7

> “We need to reduce the cost of production.”

「我們需要降低生產**成本**。」

cost = 購買、製造或完成某事所需的金錢

Natural Chinese depends on context:

* 費用

* 成本

* 價錢

* 開支

4. **cost = expense / amount spent — 開支；支出**

A broader financial noun use.

Practice 8

> “Travel **costs** have increased.”

「旅遊**開支 / 費用**上升了。」

Practice 9

> “Housing costs are very high.”

「住房**開支**很高。」

****costs = 某類活動或生活需要支付的各項費用****

Plural ****costs**** often means:

> expenses

5. ****cost = loss or sacrifice required — 代價****

A major figurative meaning.

Practice 10

> “Success came at a high ****cost****.”

「成功付出了很高的****代價****。」

Practice 11

> “The project was completed, but at considerable personal cost.”

「項目雖然完成了，但個人付出了相當大的****代價****。」

****cost = 為得到某結果而失去、犧牲或承受的東西，不一定是金錢****

This can involve:

* time

- * health
- * relationships
- * reputation
- * energy

6. **cost someone something = 使某人失去..... ; 令某人付出代價**

A major figurative verb sense.

Practice 12

> “The mistake **cost him his job**.”

「這個錯誤令他**失去了工作**。」

Practice 13

> “The delay could cost the company customers.”

「延誤可能令公司**失去客戶**。」

cost someone something = 某件事令某人失去某物或承受某種損失

Not about direct payment.

7. **cost someone time/effort = 花費時間 / 精力**

A non-money extension.

Practice 14

> “The error **cost us several hours**.”

「這個錯誤**浪費了我們幾個小時**。」

Practice 15

> “Poor planning can cost you a lot of effort.”

「規劃不周可能會讓你**多花很多精力**。」

cost = 令某人不得不付出時間、精力或其他資源

8. **at a cost = 付出代價地；但要付出代價**

Practice 16

> “The room looked beautiful, but **at a cost**.”

「房間看起來很漂亮，但也**付出了代價**。」

Practice 17

> “The company grew quickly, but at a significant cost.”

「公司成長很快，但也付出了很大的**代價**。」

at a cost = 某結果雖然達成，但伴隨損失或負面代價

9. **at the cost of + noun = 以犧牲……為代價**

A high-value pattern.

Practice 18

> “He worked long hours **at the cost of his health**.”

「他長時間工作，**以健康為代價**。」

Practice 19

> “Speed should not come at the cost of quality.”

「速度不應**以犧牲品質為代價**。」

at the cost of = 為了得到某樣東西而犧牲另一樣東西

10. **at all costs = 不惜一切代價；無論如何**

A common fixed expression.

Practice 20

> “They wanted to avoid damaging the painting ****at all costs****.”

「他們希望****不惜一切代價****避免損壞畫作。」

Practice 21

> “She was determined to succeed at all costs.”

「她決心****不惜一切代價****成功。」

****at all costs** = 無論要付出甚麼代價都要做到******

This is figurative, not necessarily financial.

11. ****cost-effective** = 具成本效益的 ; 划算的******

A very common business adjective compound.

Practice 22

> “Digital printing can be more ****cost-effective****.”

「數碼印刷可能更****具成本效益****。」

Practice 23

> “We need a cost-effective solution.”

「我們需要一個****成本效益高 / 划算****的方案。」

****cost-effective** = 所付成本與得到的效果相比值得、合理******

Important:

> cost-effective ≠ cheap

Something can be expensive but still cost-effective if it delivers strong value.

12. ****costly** = expensive — 昂貴的******

A related adjective.

Practice 24

> “The restoration was extremely **costly**.”

「修復工程非常**昂貴**。」

Practice 25

> “It was a costly piece of equipment.”

「那是一件很**昂貴**的設備。」

costly = 需要花很多金錢的

13. **costly** = causing serious loss/damage — 代價高昂的；造成重大損失的

A figurative adjective meaning.

Practice 26

> “It was a **costly mistake**.”

「那是一個**代價高昂的錯誤**。」

Practice 27

> “The delay proved costly.”

「延誤結果造成了**重大損失**。」

costly = 帶來嚴重金錢、時間、機會或其他損失的

14. **costing** = process of calculating costs — 成本計算；成本核算

A major business/accounting meaning.

Practice 28

> “The finance team prepared a detailed **costing**.”

「財務團隊準備了詳細的**成本核算**。」

Practice 29

> “We need a full costing before approving the project.”

「批准項目前，我們需要完整的**成本計算**。」

costing = 計算某產品、項目或服務需要多少成本的過程 / 結果

15. **cost something out = calculate detailed cost — 核算成本**

Since we normally avoid phrasal verbs, I'll only flag this because it belongs directly to the business sense:

> **cost something out** = 詳細計算某項目成本

Example:

> “The project has already been costed.”

「這個項目已經完成**成本核算**。」

This leads to an important irregularity.

16. **costed = calculated the cost of something — 已核算成本**

Normally past tense of **cost** is:

> cost

But in business/accounting:

> **costed**

is possible when **cost** means:

> calculate the cost of something.

Practice 30

> “The project was carefully **costed** before approval.”

「項目在批准前已仔細**核算成本**。」

Practice 31

> “We have costed the new design.”

「我們已經為新設計**計算了成本**。」

****costed = 對項目、產品或方案作成本核算****

This is a very useful exception.

17. ****cost price = 成本價****

A commercial compound.

Practice 32

> “The shop sold the item at ****cost price****.”

「商店以****成本價****出售該商品。」

Practice 33

> “The cost price does not include profit.”

「****成本價****不包括利潤。」

****cost price = 賣方取得 / 生產商品所支付的成本，不包括利潤****

18. ****cost of living = 生活成本****

A major economic compound.

Practice 34

> “The ****cost of living**** has risen.”

「****生活成本****上升了。」

Practice 35

> “Housing is a major part of the cost of living.”

「住屋是**生活成本**的重要部分。」

cost of living = 維持日常生活所需支付的整體費用

19. **labour cost / production cost / operating cost = 人工成本 / 生產成本 / 營運成本**

A business/accounting family.

Practice 36

> “Higher energy prices increased production **costs**.”

「能源價格上升令生產**成本**增加。」

Practice 37

> “The company is trying to reduce operating costs.”

「公司正嘗試降低**營運成本**。」

cost — business = 生產、經營或提供服務所需支付的資源 / 金錢

20. **legal costs = 訴訟費用；法律費用**

A common legal meaning.

Practice 38

> “The losing side may have to pay the legal **costs**.”

「敗訴一方可能需要支付**訴訟費用**。」

Practice 39

> “Legal costs can be substantial.”

「**法律費用 / 訴訟費**可能相當高。」

costs — legal = 因法律程序、律師服務或訴訟產生的費用

In legal contexts, plural **costs** is especially common.

21. **social/environmental cost** = 社會 / 環境代價

A common academic/policy use.

Practice 40

> “Air pollution creates serious social **costs**.”

「空氣污染帶來嚴重的**社會代價**。」

Practice 41

> “The environmental cost of the project was high.”

「這個項目的**環境代價**很高。」

cost = 某活動對社會、環境或其他群體造成的負面影響 / 負擔

This is figurative-economic rather than a direct invoice.

Important distinction: **cost vs price**

price

= the amount a seller asks for an item.

cost

= what the buyer must pay, or what producing/doing something requires.

> price of the painting

> = 畫作標價

> cost of producing the reproduction

> = 製作複製品的成本

In everyday shopping they can overlap, but conceptually they differ.

Important distinction: **cost vs expense**

cost

broad:

the amount required or sacrificed.

expense

money actually spent, especially as part of personal/business spending.

> production cost

> = 生產成本

> travel expense

> = 旅費 / 差旅開支

Important distinction: **cost vs fee**

cost

general amount required.

fee

charge for a service, professional work, admission, membership, etc.

> cost of the trip

> = 旅程總花費

> museum entrance fee

> = 博物館入場費

Important distinction: **cost vs charge**

cost

what something requires from the buyer/user.

charge

amount demanded by the seller/provider.

> “The repair cost me \$200.”

= 我花了 200 元。

> “They charged me \$200.”

= 他們向我收了 200 元。

Perspective differs.

Important distinction: **cost** vs **worth**

You already have **worth** mapped.

cost

= how much you have to pay.

worth

= how much value something has / whether it deserves the cost.

> “It costs \$5,000.”

= 它要價 5,000 元。

> “It is worth \$5,000.”

= 它值 5,000 元。

> “It is worth buying.”

= 值得買。

Very important contrast for your passage.

Important distinction: **cost** vs **value**

cost

= resources spent.

value

= usefulness, importance, or monetary worth.

Something can:

> cost little but have great value.

= 花費很少但價值很高。

Important distinction: **cost vs afford**

Your passage also contains **afford**.

cost

asks:

> How much money is required?

afford

asks:

> Can the person comfortably pay it?

> “It costs \$5,000.”

= 要 5,000 元。

> “I can’t afford it.”

= 我負擔不起。

Different perspective.

Important distinction: **cost vs spend**

cost

subject = thing/service.

> "The frame cost \$500."

spend

subject = person.

> "I spent \$500 on the frame."

So:

> The frame cost me \$500.

> I spent \$500 on the frame.

Same transaction, different grammar.

Important distinction: **cost vs pay**

cost

= amount required.

pay

= give money.

> "It cost \$100."

> "I paid \$100."

Different grammatical focus.

Important distinction: **cost vs costed**

This is highly testable.

Normal price sense:

> "The frame **cost** \$500." 

not:

> *costed \$500* ❌

Business calculation sense:

> “The project was **costed** at \$50,000.” ✅

= 對項目進行成本核算，估算為 50,000 元。

Important distinction: **costly** vs **expensive**

expensive

usually simply high in price.

costly

can mean:

* expensive;

* causing serious loss.

> expensive painting

> = 昂貴的畫

> costly mistake

> = 代價高昂的錯誤

“Expensive mistake” is possible but less idiomatic for non-financial consequences.

Important distinction: **cost-effective** vs **cheap**

cheap

= low price.

cost-effective

= good result relative to cost.

A \$5 solution can be cheap but ineffective.

A \$5,000 solution can be cost-effective if it prevents a \$50,000 problem.

Important distinction: ****cost — money vs sacrifice****

Money:

> “The painting cost \$10,000.”

= 畫作售價 / 花費 10,000 元。

Sacrifice:

> “The success came at a cost.”

= 成功是付出代價換來的。

This is one of the strongest polysemy contrasts.

Family-extension sweep

After the full audit, the useful modern family includes:

- * ****cost — verb: money required**** = 花費 / 要價
- * ****cost + person + amount**** = 花某人.....錢
- * ****cost — noun: amount/price**** = 費用 / 成本
- * ****costs — expenses**** = 開支 / 支出
- * ****cost — sacrifice**** = 代價
- * ****cost someone something**** = 使某人失去 / 付出.....
- * ****cost someone time/effort**** = 花費 / 浪費時間精力
- * ****at a cost**** = 付出代價
- * ****at the cost of**** = 以犧牲.....為代價
- * ****at all costs**** = 不惜一切代價
- * ****cost-effective**** = 具成本效益的
- * ****costly — expensive**** = 昂貴的
- * ****costly — harmful**** = 代價高昂的
- * ****costing**** = 成本核算
- * ****costed**** = 已核算成本
- * ****cost price**** = 成本價
- * ****cost of living**** = 生活成本
- * ****production/operating cost**** = 生產 / 營運成本
- * ****legal costs**** = 法律 / 訴訟費用
- * ****social/environmental cost**** = 社會 / 環境代價

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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cost — verb: price	購買、取得或完成某事需要支付某個金額
cost + person + amount	某件事令某人需要支付指定金額
cost — noun: financial	購買、製造或完成某事所需的金錢
costs — expenses	某類活動或生活產生的各項開支
cost — sacrifice	為得到某結果而失去、犧牲或承受的代價
cost someone something	某件事令某人失去某物或承受某種損失
cost someone time/effort	令某人不得不付出額外時間或精力
at the cost of	為得到某物而犧牲另一物
at all costs	無論付出甚麼代價都要做到
cost-effective	所付成本與所得效果相比合理、值得
costly — price	需要花很多金錢的
costly — consequence	造成嚴重金錢、時間或其他損失的
costing	計算產品、服務或項目成本的過程
costed	已對某項目 / 產品進行成本核算
cost price	商品生產 / 取得成本，不包括利潤的價格
cost of living	維持日常生活所需支付的整體費用
legal costs	因法律服務或訴訟程序產生的費用
social/environmental cost	某活動對社會 / 環境造成的負面負擔或代價

For your original passage

You have two source uses:

> “It would ****cost a fortune****.”

Here:

****cost = 需要花費一大筆錢****

Natural translation:

> ****「那會貴得驚人 / 要花上一大筆錢。」****

And:

> “...that would ****cost me around three to five thousand Hong Kong dollars****...”

Here:

****cost me + amount = 令我需要支付某個金額****

Natural translation:

> **「那大概要花我三千至五千港元。」**

The highest-value contrasts are:

> **The painting costs \$5,000.** → 畫作要價 5,000 元

> **The cost is \$5,000.** → 費用 / 價格是 5,000 元

> **It cost me my job.** → 它令我失去工作

> **at the cost of health** → 以健康為代價

> **at all costs** → 不惜一切代價

> **cost-effective** → 具成本效益的

> **costly mistake** → 代價高昂的錯誤

> **costing / costed** → 成本核算 / 已核算成本

> **cost vs worth** → 花多少錢 vs 值多少 / 值不值得